## Charnia
CHAR-nee-a

- **When** 575–545 million years ago (Precambrian)
- **Fossil location** England, Australia, Canada, Russia
- **Habitat** Seafloor
- **Length** 6 in–6½ ft (0.15–2 m)

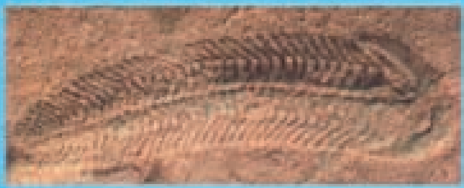
Discovered by a schoolboy in 1957, *Charnia* caused a sensation because it came from rocks thought far too old to contain animal fossils. It had a feather-shaped body and lived rooted to the seafloor by a stem, perhaps feeding on microbes filtered out of the water. Its main body was made of rows of branches that gave it a striped, quilted appearance. Some experts think its body might have housed algae that made it green and allowed it to gather energy from sunlight (photosynthesis).


◀ ANCHOR
*Some fossil of* Charnia *have a stem with a disk at the base. These disks, buried in the sandy seabed, may have been anchors that held* Charnia *fixed in place while the feathery top waved about in the current.*

## Spriggina
sprig-EEN-a

- **When** 550 million years ago (Late Precambrian)
- **Fossil location** Australia, Russia
- **Habitat** Seafloor
- **Length** 1¼ in (3 cm)

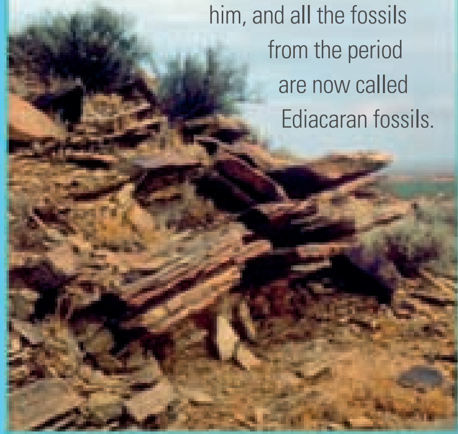
*Spriggina* may have been one of the very first animals with a front and back end. It may even have had a head with eyes and mouth, suggesting it was one of the first predators to exist. Some scientists think it may have been an early trilobite. Others liken it to worms.



▲ SEGMENTS
*Fossils show that* Spriggina*'s body was made of segments. Most fossils are curved in different ways, suggesting it had a flexible body.*

## DID YOU KNOW...?

In 1946, a scientist named Reg Sprigg was eating a packed lunch in the Ediacara Hills of Australia when he spotted what looked like jellyfish fossils in the rocks. He'd discovered something amazing: the oldest animal fossils in the world. One was named *Spriggina*, after him, and all the fossils from the period are now called Ediacaran fossils.



## Dickinsonia
dickin-SO-nee-a

- **When** 560–555 million years ago (Precambrian)
- **Fossil location** Australia, Russia
- **Habitat** Seafloor
- **Length** ⅜–39 in (1–100 cm)

One of most baffling Ediacaran fossils is *Dickinsonia*—a flat, round organism that appears to have had distinct front and back ends but no head, mouth, or gut. Studies suggest *Dickinsonia* lived fixed to the seafloor, perhaps absorbing food through its base.

▲ DICKINSONIA *fossils are usually oval, with what look like segments extending from a central groove. Hundreds of fossils have been found, with a huge variety of sizes.*

## Cyclomedusa
cy-clo-med-OO-sa

- **When** 670 million years ago (Precambrian)
- **Fossil location** Australia, Russia, China, Mexico, Canada, British Isles, Norway
- **Habitat** Seafloor
- **Length** 1–12 in (2.5–30 cm) across

Mysterious *Cyclomedusa* was originally mistaken for a jellyfish because of its circular shape, but neighboring fossils are often misshapen, as though growing around each other on the seafloor. Some scientists think *Cyclomedusa* was just a colony of microbes or the anchor for the stalk of a bigger creature.

## Parvancorina
PAR-van-coe-REE-na

- **When** 558–555 million years ago (Precambrian)
- **Fossil location** Australia, Russia
- **Habitat** Seafloor
- **Length** ⅜–1 in (1–2.5 cm)

*Parvancorina* had a shield-shaped front end that may have been a head and that faced into the current when it was alive. It also had a central ridge flanked by what look like segments. Many fossils have a well-preserved shape, suggesting that its body had a hardened outer casing.